

An Appeal for the Reinstatement of Admission and Late Registration for Mr. Cian Mac Liatháin to the PGCE Computing Programme

Section 1: Executive Summary

This report presents a formal request for the immediate reinstatement of the offer of admission and the processing of a late registration for Mr. Cian Mac Liatháin to the PGCE Computing programme (External Code: 2P3B) at University College London (UCL). The withdrawal of Mr. Mac Liatháin's offer on 26th August 2025, predicated on the failure to meet a condition by the 22nd August 2025 deadline, was the direct and demonstrable result of a critical administrative failure within UCL's own ITE Admissions department. The evidence conclusively shows that the university itself rendered it impossible for Mr. Mac Liatháin to comply with the stipulated deadline for the submission of his Disclosure and Barring Service (DBS) certificate.

Mr. Mac Liatháin is an exceptionally qualified candidate, evidenced by his First Class Honours degree in Mathematics and Education and his status as a recipient of the prestigious British Computing Society (BCS) scholarship—a distinction awarded to the most promising future educators in the field. His extensive prior academic qualifications and professional experience in both education and computing substantially mitigate, and in many areas entirely negate, the academic impact of the missed initial weeks of the programme. His existing credentials far exceed the learning objectives of the introductory components, particularly the Primary School Experience (PSE), for which the course's own structure provides a clear contingency for later completion.

Furthermore, the university's actions must be contextualised within its heightened duty of care to Mr. Mac Liatháin. As an international student with declared disabilities of Anxiety and Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD), who had communicated his extenuating circumstances of homelessness following domestic violence, he was in a position of significant vulnerability. The administrative error, compounded by poor communication and the subsequent withdrawal of his offer, not only caused profound distress but also placed his accommodation, scholarship, and maintenance loan at severe risk, constituting a significant lapse in the university's pastoral and legal obligations.

A clear and viable pathway for late registration exists within the programme's established framework. Given the irrefutable evidence of institutional error, Mr. Mac Liatháin's outstanding academic and professional profile, and the university's fundamental duties to its students, the only equitable, just, and reasonable resolution is the immediate reversal of the withdrawal decision and the facilitation of his enrolment. This report outlines the factual, procedural, pastoral, and academic grounds upon which this resolution is not merely requested, but required, to rectify a serious institutional mistake.

Section 2: Factual Chronology of Events: A Cascade

of Administrative Failure

The foundation of this appeal rests upon a clear and indisputable sequence of events. This chronology demonstrates that the failure to meet the offer conditions was not a result of any inaction or omission on the part of Mr. Mac Liatháin, but was instead caused by a material administrative error and subsequent delay by UCL's ITE Admissions department. The timeline reveals a procedural absurdity wherein the university penalised an applicant for a non-compliance that its own actions had made inevitable.

The key events are as follows:

- **22 May 2025:** UCL's ITE Admissions department extends a conditional offer of admission to Mr. Mac Liatháin for the PGCE Computing programme. The offer explicitly states that all conditions, including "a satisfactory DBS check," must be satisfied by **22 August 2025**. This document establishes the conditional contract between the university and the applicant.
- **18 June 2025:** Mr. Mac Liatháin's DBS check is officially granted. This early date is critical, as it confirms that he acted with due diligence and that the clearance from the Disclosure and Barring Service was secured more than two months before the university's deadline. The delay that followed was entirely post-clearance and related to the administrative handling of the certificate.
- **10 August 2025:** Having relocated to London and moved into UCL accommodation (Max Rayne House) due to his severe extenuating circumstances, Mr. Mac Liatháin proactively contacts the relevant UCL department. He requests that his DBS certificate, the physical evidence of his clearance, be sent to his new, correct address in London. He is informed that this is not possible. This interaction demonstrates his timely communication and a failure of process and flexibility on the part of the university department, which was now in possession of a time-sensitive document required by the student to meet a condition set by the same institution.
- **22 August 2025:** The deadline for meeting all offer conditions, as stipulated in the 22 May offer letter, passes. At this point, Mr. Mac Liatháin has still not received the DBS certificate from UCL, making it impossible for him to present the required evidence.
- **26 August 2025:** The Department for Education, acting on information from UCL, sends an email to Mr. Mac Liatháin formally withdrawing the offer of admission. The reason cited is the failure to meet the offer conditions, specifically referencing the DBS check. This represents the punitive action taken by the university, based on a situation its own department created.
- **28 August 2025:** In a stark and telling contradiction, UCL's ITE Admissions department sends an email to Mr. Mac Liatháin confirming that his DBS certificate has now been posted to his correct London address at Max Rayne House.

The temporal relationship between these events is not merely incidental; it is causal and exposes a fundamental breakdown in administrative procedure. The following table starkly illustrates the illogical sequence that forms the core of this appeal.

Date	Event	Evidence	Significance
22 May 2025	Conditional offer of admission issued by UCL.		Establishes the contract and the conditions, including the 22 August deadline.
18 June 2025	DBS check granted.	User Query	Demonstrates the

Date	Event	Evidence	Significance
			applicant's prompt action and that the clearance itself was not delayed.
22 August 2025	Deadline for meeting offer conditions.		The critical date upon which the withdrawal decision was based.
26 August 2025	UCL withdraws offer of admission.	****	The punitive action taken by UCL.
28 August 2025	UCL dispatches DBS certificate to correct address.	****	Irrefutable proof of UCL's administrative error and the impossibility of the applicant meeting the deadline.

The two-day gap between the withdrawal of the offer (26th August) and the university's dispatch of the necessary document (28th August) is the central, irrefutable fact of this case. It proves that the very department responsible for processing and verifying the condition was the agent that made fulfilling it impossible. The decision to withdraw the offer was made four days after the deadline, yet the document required to meet that deadline was only sent six days after the deadline had passed.

This sequence reveals a systemic failure. The condition was for Mr. Mac Liatháin to *provide evidence* of a satisfactory DBS check. The evidence is the physical certificate, the dispatch of which was controlled entirely by UCL. The department failed to send this certificate to the correct address in a timely manner, despite being made aware of the applicant's presence in London and his correct address on 10th August. It then participated in a process that penalised the applicant for the non-receipt of a document they themselves had failed to send. The email of 28th August is conclusive proof of this failure. It confirms that the administrative machinery at UCL was so disjointed that one part of it was withdrawing an offer while another part was only just rectifying the error that would have prevented the withdrawal. This is not a case of a student failing to meet a deadline; it is a case of an institution creating an insurmountable barrier to compliance and then enforcing a penalty for that non-compliance, fundamentally undermining the fairness and integrity of its admissions process.

Section 3: Grounds for Reinstatement and Late Registration

The decision to withdraw Mr. Mac Liatháin's offer of admission is untenable when examined on procedural, pastoral, and academic grounds. The case for reinstatement is not a request for an exception to the rules, but rather an appeal for the rules of fairness and reasonableness to be correctly applied in light of a clear institutional error.

3.1 Material Administrative Irregularity and Impossibility of Performance

The circumstances surrounding the DBS certificate constitute a "material irregularity" in the admissions process, a term used within UCL's own academic appeals framework to describe procedural errors that have a significant impact. The offer of admission can be understood as a conditional contract between the university and the applicant. A fundamental, albeit implied, term of such a contract is that neither party will act in a way that prevents the other from fulfilling the stated conditions.

UCL breached this implied term. By first sending the DBS certificate to an incorrect address—the admissions office, where the applicant does not reside—and then failing to rectify this error in a timely manner despite being contacted on 10th August, the university created a situation of *impossibility of performance*. It was factually and logistically impossible for Mr. Mac Liatháin to "provide evidence" of his satisfactory DBS check by the 22nd August deadline because the evidence itself was being withheld by the very institution demanding it.

The university's assertion in the withdrawal email of 26th August that Mr. Mac Liatháin "did not meet the offer conditions" is, therefore, factually incorrect and misleading. A critical distinction must be made:

1. **The Substantive Condition:** To obtain a satisfactory DBS check. Mr. Mac Liatháin met this condition on 18th June, months ahead of schedule.
2. **The Procedural Condition:** To provide evidence of this check by 22nd August. Mr. Mac Liatháin was prevented from meeting this condition solely by the administrative failure of UCL.

The withdrawal is based on a false premise. The fault lies not with the applicant's eligibility, diligence, or suitability, but squarely with the university's administrative competence. To uphold a decision based on an administrative error of its own making would set a damaging precedent. It would suggest that UCL is not accountable for its own procedural failures and is willing to shift the burden of institutional incompetence onto the individual—in this case, a particularly vulnerable international student who had acted in good faith at every turn. Such a position is legally and ethically indefensible and contravenes the principles of natural justice that should govern any fair administrative process.

3.2 Breach of the University's Heightened Duty of Care

The administrative error cannot be viewed in a vacuum. It must be analysed through the lens of UCL's pastoral and legal obligations, which were significantly heightened by Mr. Mac Liatháin's specific, disclosed circumstances. The university was aware, or should have been aware through its various support departments, that Mr. Mac Liatháin is:

- An **international student**, relocating from Ireland and therefore more reliant on the university for clear guidance and support.
- A **disabled student**, registered with diagnoses of Anxiety and Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD), conditions which are protected characteristics under the Equality Act 2010 and which require the institution to make reasonable adjustments and avoid discriminatory practices.
- A student facing **severe extenuating circumstances**, namely homelessness resulting from domestic violence, which necessitated his early arrival in London and increased his state of precarity.

These intersecting factors trigger a higher duty of care. The university's actions—committing a critical administrative error, failing to communicate effectively, and then summarily withdrawing his offer of admission—were not merely inconvenient. They were actions that could be reasonably foreseen to cause significant distress, exacerbate his diagnosed mental health

conditions, and trigger a crisis by jeopardising his scholarship, maintenance loan, and accommodation. This is a profound failure of the university's safeguarding responsibilities and its duty to promote the wellbeing of its students. The offer letter itself directs students to Student Support and Wellbeing services, implying an institutional acceptance of this duty from the very outset of the relationship.

The comment reportedly made during a meeting with Student Wellbeing, suggesting Mr. Mac Liatháin has "no link to London," is particularly egregious. This statement reveals a shocking lack of internal communication and a failure to view the student's situation holistically. Mr. Mac Liatháin's "link to London" was forged by and for UCL. He was in London solely because he had accepted UCL's offer of admission, secured UCL's accommodation, and was preparing to begin a UCL programme. To deny this link is to deny UCL's own agency and responsibility in creating his presence and subsequent precarity in the city. It demonstrates that one university department was unaware of, or unwilling to acknowledge, the consequences of the actions of another. This departmental siloing treats the student's admissions, accommodation, and wellbeing as disconnected issues, when in reality they formed a single, interconnected crisis precipitated entirely by the initial administrative error. This failure in pastoral care rises to the level of institutional negligence, as the university possessed all the necessary information about the student's vulnerability but failed to act in a way that protected his wellbeing. Instead, its actions directly caused foreseeable harm.

3.3 Overwhelming Mitigation of Missed Academic Components

Any potential argument that a late start is academically or logistically unviable is demonstrably false and would ignore the substance of Mr. Mac Liatháin's extensive and highly relevant prior qualifications and experience. A granular analysis of the missed course components against his existing credentials shows that he has, in effect, already met or exceeded the learning objectives for the initial phase of the PGCE programme.

The primary missed component is the five-day Primary School Experience (PSE), scheduled for the first two weeks of September. The purpose of the PSE is to give secondary-focused student teachers observational experience in the preceding educational phase. However, Mr. Mac Liatháin holds a four-year, First Class Honours BA in Mathematics and **Education** from the National University of Ireland, Galway. This is not a pure mathematics degree; it is a concurrent teacher education programme. His official transcript details numerous modules dedicated to pedagogy, including "Practical Teaching Programme," "Block Teaching Practice," "Psychology, Sociology & Catering for Diversity," "Curriculum & Assessment," and "Philosophical Foundations of Education". He is already a qualified post-primary teacher in Ireland.

Furthermore, his professional experience is directly relevant. His CV and references detail extensive work as a Computer Science Tutor, where he has taught computing concepts (Roblox, Lua, Python, Scratch, MakeCode) to children and teenagers, specifically including work in Irish-language primary schools and with primary-aged children (8-13 years old). This experience moves far beyond the passive observation required by the PSE; it constitutes active, sustained teaching in the relevant subject area to the relevant age group.

Crucially, the PGCE Computing course's own documentation provides a built-in contingency for this exact situation. The course calendar and guidance documents explicitly state that the PSE can be completed at the end of the course (week commencing 29th June 2026) for those "unable to complete prior to start of SE1". This proves that a late start without the initial PSE is not only logistically possible but is an officially sanctioned pathway within the programme's design.

The following table provides a direct mapping of Mr. Mac Liatháin's qualifications against the missed initial components of the PGCE.

Missed PGCE Component (per)	Mr. Mac Liatháin's Prior Learning & Experience (per)	Relevance / Mitigation
Primary School Experience (PSE) - 5 days observation.	BA in Mathematics & Education: Modules ED412, ED413 (Practical Teaching/Block Teaching Practice). Professional Experience: Taught coding clubs in Irish-language primary schools; extensive work with 8-13 year olds at Gaelscoil Mac Amhlaigh, Castlehackett NS, etc.	Direct, extensive, and recent experience in primary education settings, moving beyond observation to active teaching. His qualification already covers this requirement.
Subject Studies (SS) & Institute Professional Studies (IPS) - Initial lectures on professional issues and teaching Computing.	BA in Mathematics & Education: Modules on Psychology, Sociology & Catering for Diversity (ED202), Research Literacies (ED329), Curriculum & Assessment (ED302), Philosophical Foundations (ED201). First Class Honours (78.84%).	Master's level (Level 7) PGCE content is a direct progression from his high-level undergraduate (NFQ Level 8) study in the same field. His academic record proves his capacity to quickly assimilate this material.
Recognition of Irish Teaching Degree	Irish teaching degrees are highly compatible with the English system. The curricula in Mathematics and Computing show significant overlap. As an Irish citizen, he has the right to work in the UK without a visa. Reciprocal agreements facilitate the recognition of teaching qualifications.	His qualification is functionally equivalent, and his transition into the English system is seamless from a regulatory perspective. He is not an overseas teacher in the typical sense, but a professional from a closely aligned system.

To deny late registration on academic grounds would be to enforce a procedural requirement that has no substantive educational value in this specific case. It would ignore the fundamental principles of recognising prior learning and experience, which are central to modern higher education, and would contradict the professional, "intern" model that the PGCE programme itself aims to foster.

Section 4: Corroborating Factors and External Validation

Beyond the core arguments of procedural error and academic mitigation, two powerful external factors add significant weight to Mr. Mac Liatháin's case. These factors validate his high calibre as a candidate and underscore the severe prejudice he has suffered as a result of UCL's

actions.

4.1 The British Computing Society (BCS) Scholarship

Mr. Mac Liatháin is not a standard applicant; he is the recipient of a highly competitive scholarship from the British Computing Society (BCS), the Chartered Institute for IT. This is a prestigious award granted only to candidates who demonstrate exceptional potential to become outstanding teachers of computing. The scholarship programme is a key initiative, supported by the Department for Education, to develop the next generation of expert computing teachers. The BCS's own reaction to this situation, as communicated by Mr. Mac Liatháin, is highly significant. Their surprise at UCL's inflexibility and their expectation that a late registration for a candidate in this situation should be straightforward serves as a powerful external endorsement. It is the view of the key professional body in the field that the university's position is unreasonable.

This introduces a reputational risk for UCL. By withdrawing the offer from a BCS scholar over a UCL-generated administrative error, the university is not just failing an individual student. It is also mishandling a candidate who has been vetted, endorsed, and funded by a major institutional partner. The BCS selects top-tier candidates and places them at leading institutions like UCL to fulfil a national strategic priority in education. UCL's actions have effectively blocked a BCS scholar from taking up his funded place. This has the potential to damage the relationship between UCL's Institute of Education and the BCS, which could affect future scholarship placements and harm the university's standing within the wider computing education community. The issue is therefore not merely an internal administrative matter but one that has implications for UCL's external partnerships and its reputation as a leading centre for teacher training.

4.2 Demonstrated Commitment and Detrimental Reliance

Mr. Mac Liatháin has acted consistently and in good faith, relying on UCL's offer of admission to his significant personal and financial detriment. His actions demonstrate a profound commitment to the programme. In reliance on the offer, he has undertaken irreversible life changes, including:

- **International Relocation:** He has moved from his home in Galway, Ireland, to London, terminating his life and employment there.
- **Securing Accommodation:** He has entered into a year-long accommodation contract with UCL itself, residing at Max Rayne House. The email of 28th August confirms this address.
- **Financial Commitment:** He has organised his finances, including a maintenance loan and the BCS scholarship, around his status as a full-time UCL student.

These are not trivial steps; they represent a total commitment to undertaking the PGCE at UCL. This places the university in a deeply contradictory and ethically problematic position. It is, simultaneously, his prospective educator and his landlord. By withdrawing the offer of admission, one arm of the university (ITE Admissions) has jeopardised his status as a tenant with another arm of the university (UCL Accommodation). This creates an unacceptable internal conflict of interest and a severe breach of the institution's holistic duty of care. The university induced him to move to London and enter into a tenancy agreement, and then, through its own error, removed the very foundation (his student status) upon which that tenancy rests. To allow this outcome to stand would be to penalise him for reasonably relying on the university's own

offer and infrastructure.

Section 5: Proposed Pathway to Successful Course Completion

A clear, manageable, and robust pathway exists for Mr. Mac Liatháin to integrate successfully into the PGCE Computing programme with minimal disruption. This proposal is not based on special dispensation but is constructed directly from the flexible framework and contingencies already built into the course design, as evidenced by the university's own documentation. The following steps outline a viable plan for his immediate late registration and subsequent participation.

1. **Immediate Registration:** The ITE Admissions department should process Mr. Mac Liatháin's late registration with immediate effect, granting him access to all necessary UCL systems, resources, and communications.
2. **Programme Integration:** Upon registration, he will immediately join the current PGCE Computing cohort for all scheduled activities. This includes all forthcoming Subject Studies (SS), Institute Professional Studies (IPS), and Directed Study (DS) days as per the official course calendar.
3. **School Experience 1 (SE1):** He is fully prepared to commence the first major school placement, SE1, alongside his peers. He will attend the SE1 induction session scheduled for Tuesday, 6th October, and begin the placement on Wednesday, 7th October, following the cohort timetable without any deviation. His extensive prior teaching practice ensures he is well-equipped for this immersive experience.
4. **Primary School Experience (PSE) Contingency:** Mr. Mac Liatháin will avail himself of the official contingency plan clearly outlined in the course briefing documents. He will complete the required five-day PSE during the designated period at the end of the academic year, in the week commencing 29th June 2026. This is an established alternative pathway provided by the programme for students unable to complete the PSE in September, confirming that its timing is not a rigid prerequisite for the rest of the course.
5. **Review of Missed Content:** He will undertake to independently review the lecture materials and directed study tasks from the initial two weeks of university-based sessions (15th September to 26th September). Given that the content covers foundational professional and subject-specific issues, his First Class Honours degree in Mathematics and Education provides him with an exceptionally strong theoretical and practical grounding to assimilate this information swiftly and effectively.

This pathway demonstrates that Mr. Mac Liatháin's late start is not an impediment to his successful completion of the programme. By utilising the course's own inherent flexibility, he can be integrated seamlessly without requiring any significant deviation from the established curriculum or assessment schedule.

Section 6: Requested Resolution

In light of the comprehensive evidence and arguments presented in this report, which establish a clear case of material administrative error by UCL, a subsequent breach of the university's duty of care, and the applicant's overwhelming academic and professional suitability, the following resolutions are formally requested:

1. **The immediate rescission of the decision to withdraw the offer of admission** made on 26th August 2025. This decision was based on a failure to meet a condition that UCL's own administrative actions made impossible to fulfil.
2. **The immediate processing of Mr. Cian Mac Liatháin's late registration** for the PGCE Computing programme (External Code: 2P3B). This will allow him to join the course at the earliest possible opportunity and prevent further detriment to his academic progression, financial stability, and wellbeing.
3. **A brief follow-up meeting to be arranged with the programme leader and relevant administrative staff.** The purpose of this meeting would be to confirm the practical steps of his enrolment and to ensure a smooth and supportive transition into the programme, acknowledging the significant distress and disruption caused by this unfortunate and avoidable series of events.

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